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EXPRESS special

CHANGE DONE WITHOUT AMENDMENT OR NOTIFICATION AS REQUIRED

EC changes Form 6 for new voters, inserts section asking them about parents in SIR

Declaration Form

Applicant's Name: _____

Mobile Number: _____

Address: _____, Uttar Pradesh.

My name exists in Electoral Roll of last SIR

My parents name (Father, Mother, Grandfather, Grandmother) exists in the electoral roll of last SIR

Neither my name nor my parents name exists in the electoral roll of last SIR

A 'declaration form' inserted between part 'J' and 'K' of Form 6 on the Election Commission's ECINET portal

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 11

FOR THE first time, the Election Commission's online version of the electors' registration form, known as Form 6, has a new section that seeks the status of the

applicant's parents vis-a-vis the last Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, even though the statutory form itself has not been amended, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

This comes when over 5.58 crore names have been deleted

E. EXPLAINED

Mandate to amend

Even as EC has introduced the SIR declaration in its online Form 6 portal, Section 28 of Representation of the People Act, 1950 says it is the Centre that can amend the rules. These include any change to the forms as well — a process that has not been followed.

from electoral rolls in 10 states and three UTs in the EC's SIR
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM FLAGS BLUEPRINT FOR TRUST, TECH, TALENT

India and NZ pledge strategic partnership, to build on trade deal

Pacts signed on counter-terrorism, defence, sports, Antarctic research

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 11

INDIA AND New Zealand pledged Saturday to elevate their bilateral relationship to a "strategic partnership" with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his counterpart, Christopher Luxon, endorsing its framework and "roadmap to 2030."

Both signed a range of pacts that included defence and maritime security, a target to double trade volume, a joint counter-terrorism panel to address pro-Khalistan concerns and a sports cooperation roadmap.

After the bilateral talks in Auckland, Modi, the first Indian Prime Minister to visit the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with New Zealand PM Christopher Luxon at an Indian community event in Auckland, Saturday. ANI

A century later, Dhyan Chand tour still unites two countries

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 11

WATCHING THE Prime Ministers of India and New Zealand reminisce about his father, hockey legend Dhyan Chand, on Saturday, Ashok Kumar's heart swelled with pride.

"I feel proud that a team of

Army men, and a humble soldier in that team, did something so remarkable that even after 100 years, the Prime Ministers are talking about it, and it still connects people from both nations," he told *The Indian Express*.

Long before he became the 'Wizard of Hockey', Dhyan
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A screening of the film *Satluj* at Jangpur village of Ludhiana on Thursday night. RAAKHI JAGGA

In Punjab villages, crowds at *Satluj* shows, a chorus: 'Those dark days should never return'

OTT 'ban' driving more to watch film as AAP, SGPC, Akali Dal hold screenings

Raakhi Jagga
Jangpur (Ludhiana), July 11

AT 8.30 pm on Thursday, a vacant plot next to the Guru Tegh Bahadur Sahib Gurdwara in Jangpur village of Ludhiana is packed. Women and men sit on mats, their heads covered, including with handkerchiefs, just like at a gurdwara. The elderly occupy plastic chairs, while the young are perched on the ground's boundary walls.

Their eyes are glued onto an 85-inch screen playing *Satluj*.

The contested film on human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra that saw a brief OTT release before being blocked in India, has found a new life in Punjab, in similar mass screenings being held across the state.

Also seeing a new life are memories of "the *aukha* (dark, difficult) time" in Punjab, which those gathered at the Jangpur ground and elsewhere stress, "should not return".

While gurdwaras and the SGPC were the first to
»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Govt panel raises UAPA spectre, 'misuse' by Pak

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, July 11

IN ITS order recommending the film "*Satluj*" remain blocked from public access, the government panel has raised the spectre of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act by observing that "Khalistan-related propaganda, foreign-based separatist mobilisation, and hostile information operations are continuing concerns, with

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 12~07~2026

~:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

India, NZ

country in 40 years, said: “This marks the beginning of a new chapter in our relationship. Our shared, firm belief in democratic values creates a natural comfort for India and New Zealand and to move forward together.”

PM Luxon reciprocated: “It’s a truly historic event...a significant milestone in the New Zealand-India relationship.”

Recalling his first visit to India in his mid-20s, when he worked for Unilever, Luxon said: People got paid daily wages in coins in their hands. It’s interesting to me that under PM Modi’s leadership, he has lifted 250 million people out of poverty. There is now 440 million people in the middle class, about to be 750 million by the end of the decade. It is an incredible transformation.”

India and New Zealand agreed to double bilateral trade to NZ\$7 billion or Rs 35,000 crore by 2030, in the context of the Free Trade agreement signed in April this year.

Flagging the FTA signed in “record time” Modi said the trade deal “will open new doors for industries, farmers, and the youth of both nations.” Beyond trade, Modi underlined a “blue-print based on trust, technology,

and talent,” that will power bilateral ties to “double our trade volume over the next five years.”

“We also warmly welcome New Zealand’s commitment to invest 20 billion dollars in India. This will provide New Zealand companies with the opportunity to become long-term partners in India’s growth story,” he said.

The joint statement said that the Prime Ministers highlighted cooperation under Combined Task Force 150 (CTF-150) in 2025, with New Zealand in command and India as Deputy Commander, supporting efforts to deter narcotics smuggling, terrorism, and illicit maritime activity in the Middle East and the Western Indian Ocean.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, the two sides decided to establish a maritime security dialogue to strengthen cooperation, coordination and information exchange.

The two leaders reiterated the importance of dialogue and diplomacy, and adherence to international law to achieve a peaceful and lasting solution to the West Asia conflict. Urging “all parties to exercise restraint, de-escalate tensions, and ensure protection of civilians,” they called for “full restoration of freedom of navigation and the global flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz,

while opposing any constraints on shipping.”

The joint statement underscored stability in the Indo-Pacific and the importance of “transparent, and resilient supply chains.” It noted how disruptions have affected Pacific Island countries, where economies are “heavily exposed” and higher oil prices are driving inflation across sectors “placing significant pressure on social well-being and fiscal sustainability.”

Both leaders condemned the Pahalgam and the Red Fort terror attacks and stressed that those responsible for the attacks should be held accountable.

“The two leaders agreed to strengthen cooperation in combating terrorism and violent extremism. The leaders welcomed...establishing a Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism which will provide a framework for information and knowledge sharing,” the joint statement said, in the context of concerns from pro-Khalistan elements in New Zealand. This is significant since New Zealand is a Five-Eyes intelligence partner along with the US, UK, Canada and Australia.

The two sides also signed a pact for enhanced cooperation in animal husbandry and dairying through technical collaboration, knowledge exchange, and

best practices. They also decided to launch the ‘Kiwi fruit Action Plan and Establishment of two Centres of Excellence for Kiwi fruit in Nagaland and Uttarakhand’.

The India-New Zealand Joint Action Plan on Sport will provide a framework for collaboration in sports. The two countries also signed a pact on collaboration in Antarctic research.

Modi, who wrapped up his three-nation trip in Auckland, also got a special Maori welcome. Luxon highlighted the deep cultural alignment and the unprecedented momentum injected into the bilateral relationship. “It is fitting that your visit coincides with Matariki, the Maori New Year, which is, of course, a time to remember, to reflect and to look ahead. The same star cluster is known in Indian tradition as Kritika. Though called by different names, we share the same stars, and we share the same hope for prosperity and renewal,” he said.

Modi said, “I extend my heartiest congratulations to all of you on the Maori New Year, Matariki. Just as the star cluster here is named ‘Matariki’, as you also mentioned, it has been known in India as the ‘Kritika’ constellation since ancient times. I am confident that this year of ‘Matariki’ will inspire our relations to shine like these stars.”

Satluj

announce these screenings, the Akali Dal and now the ruling Aam Aadmi Party are also showing the Diljit Dosanjh-starrer. One of the screenings held by the AAP on Friday — with the film played on a mobile and projected onto the side of a van — was near the house in Dugri, Ludhiana, where Dosanjh moved to study music as a boy.

The Inter-Departmental Committee set up by the Centre to review *Satluj* has recommended that the movie remain blocked from access in the country as it has the potential to threaten the security of the State.

In an interview to *The Indian Express*, Khalsa’s daughter Navkiran Kaur Khalsa said that this, however, is having the opposite effect. “Ironically, the attempt to stop the film has drawn more attention to it. People are now reading about that period, discussing it and asking questions. That, in itself, is significant... Khalsa has haunted the system for three decades because the issues he raised have never been fully addressed. Until the truth is confronted honestly, his story will continue to return.”

In Jangpur, Thursday, this seems evident. The screening is organised by supporters of Dakha MLA Manpreet Singh Ayali, who is vice-president of the Akali Dal Waris Punjab De (WPD), a

splinter group of the Shiromani Akali Dal floated by supporters of jailed Independent MP and alleged Khalistan sympathiser Amritpal Singh.

Jasdeep Singh Jassa, who is overseeing the arrangements, says: “We contacted a DJ and he brought a downloaded copy of the movie. We are paying Rs 5,000 for one screening.” Jassa plans to hold three of those, “because everyone cannot watch it in a single evening”.

As he speaks, Gurdev Kaur, who is in her 70s, quietly walks out of the screening venue and sinks into a chair. Villagers rush to offer water, saying she has been unwell and felt uneasy.

Gurdev has another explanation. One hour into the film, she felt she couldn’t take any more. “*Oh sama dubara nahin chahida... Bhot aukha si* (We don’t want those days to return... They were extremely difficult).”

Jaswant Singh, 61, has come from around 2 km away, with his wife and brother. “Had they not removed the film from OTT or created controversy, people probably would not have gathered in villages to watch it,” he says.

It’s all politics and vested interests, he adds. “With elections approaching, the timing is perfect... We know everything.”

During the height of the militancy, Jaswant had moved his entire family to West Bengal where he was posted in the Army. And so he cautions against reading too much into

people flocking to the screenings. “*Eh film nu movement na samjho* (Don’t mistake this for a movement). It’s just an attempt to revisit our painful past.”

Around 9 km away, at Gahour village, a screening at a park near a gurdwara has drawn over 1,000 people. Around 9 pm, the organisers who are workers of the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akali Dal announce a short interval, serving sherbat and samosas. One of the party workers, Vicky Chaudhary, says he has coordinated screenings at Mohi, Gahour and Sawaddi villages.

There is no politics behind it, Chaudhary, 52, insists. “We simply want people to know their past... and learn lessons so that such an era never returns.” At the screening at Deharka village about 40 km from Ludhiana city, Akali Dal leader Chand Singh Dalla is present. While announcing another show at his native village the next day, he suddenly falls silent.

A villager explains in a whisper: “His uncle was picked up in the early 1990s and never returned.”

Later, Dalla talks about the episode. “He was a doctor and a retired Army man. Four men in civil clothes and carrying carbines arrived, forced my uncle into their vehicle and drove away. That was the last time we saw him.”

It was often hard to tell who the perpetrator was, Dalla adds. “Nearly 20 youngsters from our

village died during that period. Some in rivalries, some after being picked up by police, perhaps others at the hands of militants. God alone knows.”

A 75-year-old retired Punjab State Electricity Board employee from Mullanpur, who does not want to be identified, worries about “the politics behind the row”. “The movie shows what happened during Congress governments and later. Now different parties have their own political interests in taking the film to villages,” he says, pointing out that Congress-turned-BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu’s motive seems to be to defend his grandfather Beant Singh, who headed the Congress government in the state at the time of Khalsa’s killing. (Khalsa disappeared six days after Beant Singh’s assassination.)

At Jangpur, Dilip Singh, 24, says that as a youngster who did not see the period, he wants the government to know “not to fear the past”. “We watched *Satluj* because we were stopped from watching it. The government should let people realise what happened.”

At Sawaddi village, organiser Aman Sawaddi feels the film ban, the screenings may turn out to be for the best. “Were we not watching the film together, perhaps we would never have recalled those horrific times so vividly.” It is making their resolve stronger, he adds. “May those days never return.”

Form 6

that began last year, raising questions about the potential impact on their children. In the case of West Bengal, which saw an unprecedented process payout, over 27 lakh electors were deleted during adjudication and were unable to vote in the April elections while their appeals remain pending before tribunals.

The EC’s ECINET portal, as accessed Saturday, showed an un-lettered “declaration form” part inserted in between part “J” and “K” of Form 6 that asks for details of the applicant or their parents in the last SIR. But the copy of the Form 6 available for download on the same portal, ostensibly for filling and submitting physically, does not include this new declaration part.

This part of the form was visible for applicants from all states and UTs where the SIR has concluded in 2025-2026 or is currently ongoing, except for Bihar, which was the first state to have the SIR in June last year, and Assam, where the EC has decided not to hold the SIR.

While the new part has not been marked mandatory, the user cannot move forward toward the submission before completing it.

It asks the applicant to pick from three options: “my name exists in Electoral Roll of last SIR; my parents name (Father, Mother, Grandfather, Grandmother) exists in the electoral roll of last SIR; neither my name nor my parents name exists in the electoral roll of last SIR”.

Upon selecting the first two options, the applicant is then required to provide the Assembly constituency, booth number and serial number of their or their parents’ name in the last SIR, which was held in the early 2000s or earlier this year for 12 states/UTs. In case the applicant cannot find the details, the only option is to select the third one. But the portal does not say what will happen if the applicant selects the last option.

While the EC sought the same details during the SIR in 12 states/UTs last year and also in the ongoing SIR in 19 states/UTs in its enumeration form for existing electors, Form 6 for new electors has not been amended since the EC started in SIR in June last year, a look at all gazette notifications by the Law Ministry since then shows.

It is the Central government that has the power to notify rules under Section 28 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 and Form 6 emanates from one such rule in the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The Act itself emanates from Article 326 of the Constitution, which guarantees the right to enrol as an elector to all adult citizens who are ordinarily resident in a particular constituency and have not been otherwise disqualified.

“The Central Government may, after consulting the Election Commission, by notification in the Official Gazette, make rules for carrying out the purposes of this Act,” reads Section 28 of the RP Act, 1950.

In the past, changes to Form 6 required an amendment to the Act itself by Parliament and/or an amendment and notification to the rules by the Law and Justice Ministry. Two senior former EC officials speaking on condition of anonymity said any change to the form would require at least an amendment and notification by the Law Ministry as the EC does not have the power to do so.

“The EC cannot even add a comma to the form on its own,” one of the former officials said.

For instance, after Parliament amended the Act in 2021 to allow the EC to collect Aadhaar numbers of electors, the Legislative Department of the Law Ministry issued a notification on June 17, 2022 making the necessary changes to the Registration of Electors Rules and Form 6.

The EC did not respond to a request for comment and Legislative Department Secretary Rajiv Mani could not be reached despite repeated attempts.

EXPRESS special

Inside a cybercrime trail: 96 ‘mule accounts’ in one Delhi bank branch, hunt on for facilitator

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 11

THE FIRST clue that something was unusual was not a cyber fraud complaint, but a private bank branch in North-east Delhi.

During Delhi Police's Cyber Hawk operation in April, investigators identified 96 suspected mule accounts linked to the private bank branch — one of the biggest concentrations of suspected money-laundering accounts uncovered during the crackdown on organised cybercrime.

Every cyber fraud needs somewhere for the money to go. Before it reaches overseas operators or cryptocurrency wallets, it usually passes through several “mule accounts” belonging to ordinary people who have either rented out their accounts for a commission or surrendered control of them without understanding how they would be used.

This Northeast Delhi branch became one such concentration point. And one of those 96 accounts belonged to a 30-year-old unemployed local resident.

In March, while visiting his uncle undergoing treatment at GTB Hospital, the man was approached by a man in his 40s

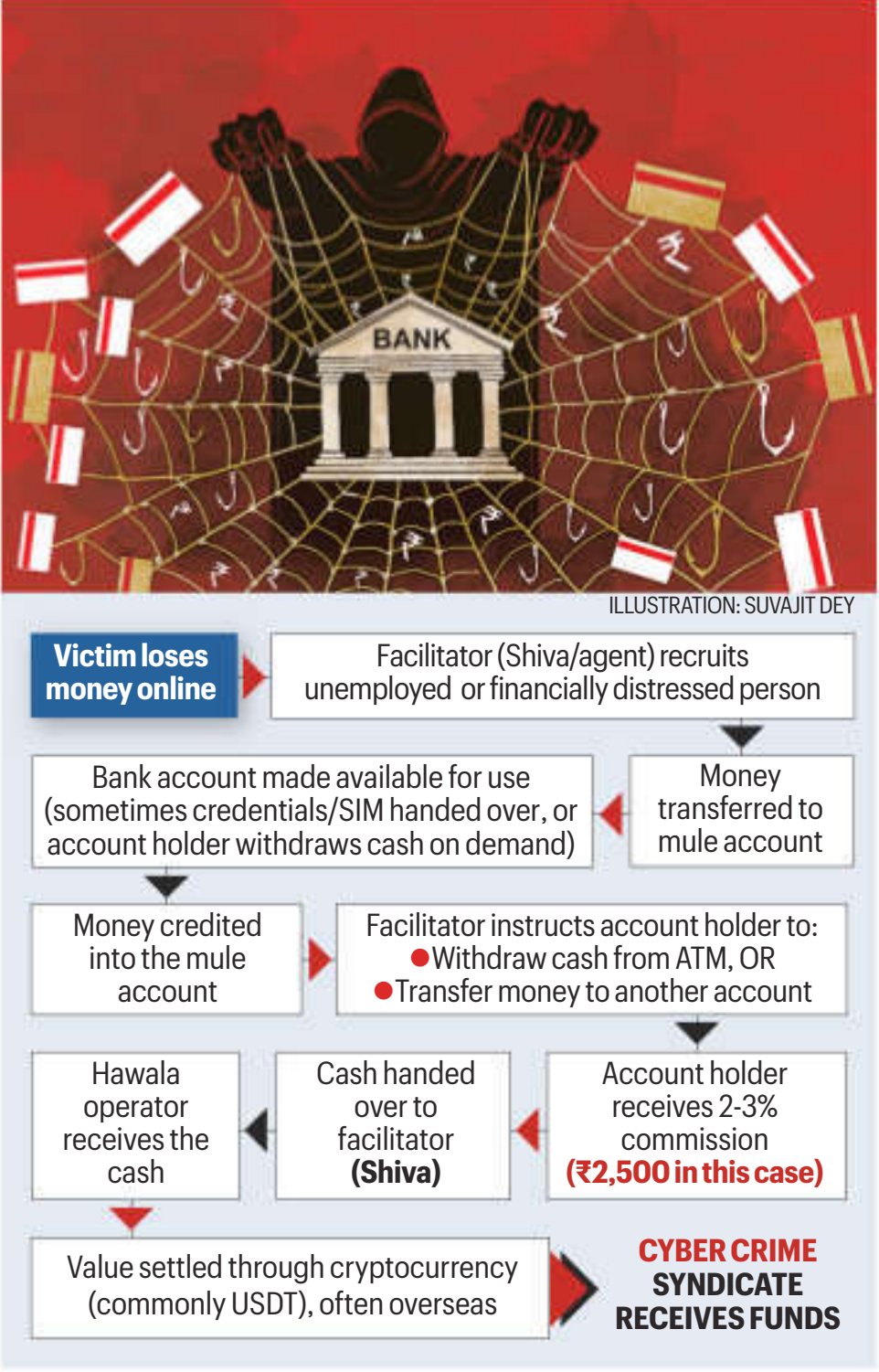
who introduced himself as 'Shiva'. Claiming that his mother was ill and that he urgently needed cash but could not withdraw money from his own account, the man requested help.

Trusting him, the 30-year-old allowed around Rs 30,000 to be transferred into his account. He withdrew Rs 25,000 from a nearby ATM and added another Rs 5,000 from his own pocket. Two days later, Shiva contacted him again, saying another Rs 24,000 had been transferred to his account “by mistake”. The man initially refused to return it if such transfers continued, but later met Shiva again at GTB Hospital and handed over the money.

Weeks later, his account was frozen and the man was detained after police said he was linked to two cyber fraud complaints from outside Delhi involving Rs 30,000 and Rs 24,000. Police said the man later admitted he had accepted Rs 2,500 as commission for allowing the transactions, although he maintained he did not know the money was linked to cyber fraud. He was bound down and released.

The man, who lives with his wife and two-and-a-half-year-old son, has studied till Class 10. He earlier sold mobile phone

•CYBER FRAUD MONEY FLOW



chargers before losing his livelihood during the Covid-19 pandemic and now survives on occasional daily-wage work.

Investigators said his experience matches a pattern.

Police said cyber financial fraud typically operates in two parts — one that cheats victims and another that manages and launders the stolen money.

Facilitators — several of them are unemployed — often recruited through Telegram, Signal and Instagram, arrange bank accounts for cybercriminals and move the proceeds through hawala channels before they are ultimately through cryptocurrency transactions, particularly using USDT.

To set up mule accounts, facilitators identify unemployed youth, daily-wage labourers and financially distressed people and persuade them to let their bank accounts be used. Some knowingly rent out their accounts for a commission of 2-3% of the money routed through them. They hand over their SIM cards, banking credentials and account access, allowing the accounts to be operated remotely.

In this case, police said the facilitator Shiva allegedly paid the 30-year-old Rs 2,500 for allowing Rs 54,000 of suspected fraud proceeds to pass

through his account.

DCP (Northeast) Rahool Alwal constituted a special team led by inspectors Rahul Kumar and Satyawan Lathwal, leading investigators to identify 96 suspected mule accounts linked to the bank branch.

The probe found that digital credentials used to access the 30-year-old's account originated from Tamil Nadu. Teams sent there found linked bank accounts that had allegedly been opened using fake Aadhaar cards.

Investigators also found several accounts opened using forged documents. A case was registered under BNS.

The concentration of suspected mule accounts in a single branch prompted investigators to examine whether insiders knowingly facilitated account openings, whether the online onboarding process had weakened customer verification, or whether fake Know Your Customer documents had bypassed checks. However, no evidence has yet emerged establishing the involvement of any bank official, police said.

Police have so far been unable to trace Shiva. “The mobile number used was obtained using fake documents. The name could also be fake,” an officer said.

UN Special Rapporteurs flag ‘discrimination’ in SIR exercise, seek govt’s response

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 11

THREE UNITED Nations-appointed experts have written to the Centre expressing concerns over alleged discrimination towards minorities during the Election Commission’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, particularly in West Bengal, and seeking information on the steps taken to ensure the process aligns with India’s obligations under international human rights law.

The UN’s Special Rapporteurs on minority issues, on promotion and protection of the right to freedom of opinion and expression, and on freedom of religion or belief — Nicolas Levrat, Irene Khan and Nazila Ghanea respectively —

wrote to the government on May 1. They sought the government’s comments on allegations that Bengali and Muslim electors were targeted during the SIR and asked for details of steps taken to ensure that eligible voters were not prevented from participating in the 2026 Assembly polls.

The SIR exercise was upheld by the Supreme Court in May this year. Dismissing the petitions challenging the legality of SIR, the court ruled that the EC had the power to conduct the exercise.

“We are particularly concerned by the way in which the SIR process has been conducted, notably the reported removal of millions of voters’ names from electoral rolls, potentially affecting a great number of Muslims



In West Bengal, 27 lakh electors were unable to cast their votes in the April 2026 polls even as their appeals are pending with tribunals. FILE

and persons of Bengali descent, as well as other minorities, who may be wrongfully excluded from the updated electoral rolls because of their historical and

continuing treatment as foreigners and illegal immigrants, notably in West Bengal,” the letter states.

Emails sent to the spokes-

person for the MEA and the EC did not elicit a response.

The letter comes after a group of academics, the Independent Panel for Monitoring Indian Elections, submitted complaints regarding the SIR exercise to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights in August 2025 and April 2026. The panel comprises Prof Neera Chandhoke, a Distinguished Honorary Fellow at the Centre for Equity Studies, Dr Thomas Daffern, a historian and director of the International Institute of Peace Studies and Global Philosophy and Dr Harish Karnick, a former IIT-Kanpur professor.

The coordinator of the independent panel, retired IAS officer MG Devasahyam, said the

group recently received a copy of the letter, which was made public by the Special Rapporteurs after 60 days, as per their practice.

“Affected individuals of the second phase [of SIR] report being wrongfully excluded despite having provided valid identification. Muslim voters were reportedly disproportionately impacted by the SIR process... Minor spelling inconsistencies in documents — reportedly common across India due to administrative challenges — are allegedly used as a pretext for the deletion of voter names,” the letter states.

On the SIR in Bihar, the letter says it reportedly caused alarm over potential large-scale disenfranchisement and denationalisation, particularly of

Muslims and other minorities. “Further concerns have been raised by the alleged use of an AI-driven system that flagged ‘irregularities’ in voter data, raising concerns about transparency, errors, and potential bias,” the letter states.

It also flags concerns over statements made by political and government officials in the context of the SIR.

“In the context of the SIR process, statements were reportedly made by politicians and senior public figures of the Government, which appear to reflect and reinforce a pattern of discriminatory rhetoric directed at Muslim, Bengali, and other minority communities. Senior Government officials, including the Union Home Minister, have reportedly pub-

licly framed the deletion of voter names as targeting ‘illegal Bangladeshi immigrants’ — rhetoric that conflates legitimate Indian Muslim citizens with foreign nationals.”

“It is also reported that, before Parliament, the Home Minister framed the State-administered electoral process in terms of the removal of a religious community, expressed through the policy formula ‘Detect, Delete and Deport’,” the letter states.

The EC started the SIR in Bihar in June last year and then followed it up in 10 states and three UTs, including West Bengal, from October 2025. In West Bengal, 27 lakh electors were unable to cast their votes in the April 2026 polls even as their appeals are pending with tribunals.

Future wars will still be won by soldiers, not just AI: Rajnath

Press Trust of India
Visakhapatnam, July 11

FUTURE WARS may be fought with Artificial Intelligence, but they will still be won by national resolve, trained soldiers and robust military power, Defence Minister Rajanath Singh said on Saturday.

Speaking at the commissioning ceremony of INS Mahendragiri, Singh also said Andhra Pradesh has emerged as a new powerhouse of India's defence and aerospace manufacturing.

Highlighting the government's balanced approach towards defence modernisation, Singh said India is investing in next-generation tech while simultaneously strengthening conventional military capabilities.

He cited Operation Sindoor as an example of the effective integration of conventional and modern capabilities to



INS Mahendragiri during its commissioning ceremony in Visakhapatnam on Saturday. PTI

safeguard national security.

"Future wars may be fought with Artificial Intelligence, but they will still be won by national resolve, trained soldiers and the capable military power. So, I would say that new technologies and conventional platforms are not opposed to each other, but supplement each other, complete each other. Without conventional platforms, new technologies are incomplete in themselves," he

said.

According to Singh, it is certain that new technologies have reshaped warfare, but they have not diminished the role of conventional warfare means.

The strong conventional capability still necessary for the fulfilment of basic principles of war is as important as it was before. Referring to the Indian Navy's role during the recent West Asia conflict, Singh said under Operation Urja Suraksha, the Navy safely escorted 18 merchant vessels carrying essential cargo valued at more than Rs 9,000 crore.

Describing INS Mahendragiri as a "blue-water warship", Singh said it can effectively counter threats from the air, enemy vessels on the surface and submarines hidden beneath the sea, and can protect India's maritime interests not only near the coastline but also in distant and deep oceans during prolonged deployments.

Food regulator pulls up Instamart over spoilt, contaminated food

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, July 11

AFTER COMPLAINTS by consumers against quick commerce app Swiggy Instamart, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has served nine notices to the company. The complaints were regarding the supply of expired, spoilt, rotten or contaminated food products.

No action was taken by the company even on escalation of complaints by the consumers.

The company was also found to list products on its platform that carried names other than what was mentioned on FSSAI licence of the food operator.

The food regulator said: "Complainants alleged delivery of contaminated eggs and milk, along with damaged packaged food items through Instamart. Some complainants alleged that no satisfactory response, grievance redressal or corrective action was taken despite the complaints being escalated, while one complainant stated that only a refund was offered without addressing the reported food safety concerns."

According to details provided by the FSSAI, consumers complained that 'Healthify 100% Whey Protein 1kg' and 'Noice Homestyle Madras Mixture with Peanuts' were supplied after their expiry date. 'Akshayakalpa Organic Eggs' were not only expired, but consumers said they found it to be emitting foul odour. In this case, when the consumers escalated their complaint, no corrective action was taken by Swiggy Instamart.

Another product, 'Kakke da Paratha', was found spoilt and emitting foul odour but the company did not take any action on the complaint. Consumers complained that the infant food formula they received was in an unsafe condition, showing signs of improper storage and handling. The consumers said the platform allegedly re-supplied defective product after they returned it.

FSSAI also found that the platform marketed 'Noice Eggs' under a brand name not covered by the existing licence. It has asked the company not to market products unless it was covered by a valid licence.

CANADA TRADE MINISTER TO LEAD BUSINESS DELEGATION IN OCT

‘Canada CEPA intends to provide preferential market access in India’

Divya A

New Delhi, July 11

AS INDIA and Canada aim to close in on the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) by this year-end, the office of Canadian Minister of International Trade told *The Indian Express* that besides enhancing transparency and predictability in trade relations, the agreement “is intended to provide” preferential market access for Canadian goods and services in the world’s fifth largest economy.

Negotiators from India and Canada were engaged in the third round of CEPA talks this week in Ottawa between July 6 and 10.

The agreement will also support more resilient supply chains, and broader global stability, says the office of Canadian Minister of International Trade, Maninder Sidhu, in response to email queries by *The Indian Express* on the CEPA talks — seen as the first concrete outcome of rebuilding of ties between the two sides.

While India offers market scale and long-term demand, Canada brings capital and technology. Asked if he thinks that the CEPA will be a force multiplier, his office said that in negotiating the agreement with India, our objective is to create opportunities and benefits for Canadian businesses, workers and families by reducing trade barriers, and creating rules that will enhance predictability for traders.

“The agreement is intended to provide new preferential market access for Canadian goods



Maninder Sidhu, Canadian Minister of International Trade

and services in the world’s fifth largest economy. It will also enhance transparency and predictability in trade relations and strengthen access to Indian supply chains,” the office said.

Sidhu is set to lead a business delegation from the country to India in October this year.

With Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney inviting Prime Minister Narendra Modi to visit the country this year, Sidhu’s office says, “Canada’s engagements with India continue to see positive momentum as we have taken important steps to rebuild trust and establish more structured economic dialogue.”

Last month, PM Modi and PM Carney met on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in France.

Relations plummeted in 2023 over then PM Justin Trudeau’s allegation of “potential” involvement of Indian government agents in the killing of Canada-based Khalistan separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar — a charge that India rejected as “absurd” and “motivated”.

The first step in the restoration of bilateral relations began after Modi and Carney met at the G7 leaders’ Summit in Kananaskis in June 2025.

Sidhu — who was born in Punjab and moved to Brampton in his childhood along with his parents — now represents the Brampton East constituency.

India and Canada have spent 15 years trying to translate economic complementarity into a formal trade arrangement. Asked if he thinks that this time both sides are trying to work out a practical agreement as a culmination of all those years of effort, Sidhu’s office said, “Canada’s engagements with India continue to see positive momentum as we have taken important steps to rebuild trust and establish more structured economic dialogue.”

Canada is pleased with progress made during the 2nd round of the CEPA negotiations, which took place in New Delhi on May 4-8, and with the inter-sessional meetings on the margins of Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal’s visit to Ottawa and Toronto in May, the office said.

Amid the geopolitical turmoil over US tariffs and the repercussions on energy supplies arising out of the West Asia conflict, the two sides now aim to collaborate on key sectors. On this, Sidhu’s office said, “Opportunities between Canada and India remain strong, including in energy, critical minerals, agri-food, digital and clean technologies, education, and services, providing a solid basis for deeper economic cooperation.”

“These areas draw on complementary strengths and can support more resilient supply chains, sustainable growth, and broader global stability, as underscored in the joint statement,” the office said.

EXPRESS special

Daughter alive, Maharashtra man jailed for her ‘murder’ says ‘no compensation, apology yet’

Ankita Deshkar

Nagpur, July 11

FOR 22 DAYS, Bapuram Kalmekar sat in jail for the alleged “murder” of his daughter. Then his daughter, Shivani, walked into a police station.

This week, Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis admitted in the Assembly that the police had committed a “serious mistake”, arresting the 55-year-old daily wage labourer and his son without scientifically establishing that the burnt, headless body was Shivani.

He announced the suspension of the investigating officers, directed that criminal cases be registered against them, ordered a departmental inquiry to be completed within three months, and announced compensation for the family.

More than a month after his release, Kalmekar, a resident of Khadki village in MP’s Burhanpur district, says none of it has reached him. “No police officer has apologised to me till date,” Kalmekar told *The Indian Express*. “No one has contacted me regarding any financial assistance. I came to know about the CM’s announcement only after someone showed me a video.”

Knock on the door

In May, six policemen from Maharashtra’s Buldhana district, along with a local constable, arrived at Kalmekar’s house in MP’s Khadki village, where he was staying with his

CM Fadnavis said police committed a ‘serious mistake’; officers suspended



Bapuram Kalmekar and Ajay Kalmekar were picked up by Maharashtra Police from their home in MP’s Khadki village

son Ajay (28). “They told me my daughter, Shivani, had died and they had found her body,” he recalled.

“They told me they were taking me to identify her body, but instead they kept me at Khaknar police station for a night and a day. I never saw her body,” he said.

What followed, he alleges, was assault and coercion. “They started beating us. They separated me from Ajay. They told me my son had confessed, and they told my son that I had confessed. Believing that my son had admitted to it, I too said ‘yes’ under pressure. I was tired,” he said.

“We started saying yes to everything the police asked us,” said Ajay. The duo were arrested for what police alleged was an “honour” killing. “I kept telling the police that I had not killed

my daughter,” Kalmekar said.

On the allegations of custodial torture, Buldhana SP Nilesh Tambe said, “Departmental inquiry is on. All allegations will be verified.”

A complaint, a body, a theory

In April last week, Kalmekar lodged a missing person’s complaint at Khaknar police station. Shivani, who was married, had come to her parental home where she again met Arun Kalmekar, a resident of Khadki village, and both of them vanished, the police learnt.

This came out during the interrogation of Bapuram and Ajay by the Maharashtra Police, said Inspector Abhishek Jadhaw, Khaknar police station SHO.

“Shivani was married and

had come to her parental home for a few days when she and Arun met again. Based on this information, we registered a missing person’s complaint for Arun on May 9 and began searching for Arun after Maharashtra Police told us about Shivani’s murder,” Jadhaw said.

Days after the complaint of Shivani was filed, a partially burnt, headless body of an unidentified woman was found near a riverbank in Buldhana district. A human skull was recovered about 100 m away.

The Indian Express has learnt that the Maharashtra Police had scanned the missing persons complaints in neighbouring districts and apparently found a match with the description of Shivani in the complaint since the body seemed to be of the same age.

However, investigators did not scientifically establish the identity of the body before arresting her father and brother.

Maharashtra Police, Jadhaw said, had informed them that the missing woman had been identified as the victim found in Buldhana.

A theory was built around the arrests. Police said that Bapuram and Ajay allegedly killed Shivani because she was in a relationship with her cousin despite being married.

According to investigators, Bapuram beat his daughter to death with a bamboo stick on April 23 night. After keeping the body overnight, the father-son

duo took it on a motorcycle 100 km away to Rajura farmland in Buldhana, burnt it, severed the head and dumped the remains at different locations, they said.

Police claimed that the blood-stained clothes and the “murder” weapon were discarded elsewhere.

None of it, as it turned out, had happened.

The case collapses

Khaknar SHO Jadhaw said that after Maharashtra Police claimed that the woman had been killed by her family, they launched a search for Arun.

“We later learnt he had travelled elsewhere in search of daily-wage work. When we traced him, we found Shivani was staying with him,” Jadhaw said.

“We initially detained them in Nagpur. After gaining their confidence, we advised both of them to come to Burhanpur, Madhya Pradesh. We verified that the woman was indeed Shivani through various methods, including biometric details. We then advised her to appear before Jalgaon Jamod police station in Maharashtra,” he said.

With Shivani’s entry at the police station, the “murder” case imploded.

Detained on May 9, Bapuram and Ajay were released after 22 days in jail. A question lurks: The identity of the woman whose decapitated body was found in Buldhana. She’s yet to be identified, SP Tambe told *The Indian Express*.

Two CMs and their *revdi* secrets



OFF THE RECORD
BY P VAIDYANATHAN IYER

TWO SECRETS shared with this writer by two Chief Ministers, one from the Bharatiya Janata Party and the other from the Congress, give a sense of the dilemmas they face, and the political tight-rope they walk. While the identity of the CMs and the states they represent is not pertinent, the message these secret anecdotes deliver is important. It shows just how serious a problem the two CMs face — on the political and fiscal front.

A macro-economic risk that worries those closely following India's federal polity is the worsening financial health of states — slowing revenues, rising expenditure, and an increasing debt to fund the revenue-expenditure gap. Some states such as Telangana, Bihar and Himachal Pradesh struggle to pay salaries to their employees, while some others like Punjab and West Bengal do not have enough to spend on

roads and bridges, or infrastructure, that will help their economy grow.

Yet, come state Assembly elections, leaders of big political parties including the BJP and the Congress do not shy away from announcing new schemes with cash handouts, trying to please different sections of voters — women, the unemployed, and many more.

Secret 1 of a state Chief Minister has its origins in this battleground of competitive populism. This Chief Minister, from a BJP-ruled state, finds himself in a piquant situation during elections in other states. His state does not have any scheme which makes large monthly cash transfers of the kind most other states indulge in. So, when he is called to campaign for his party during elections in other states, he is in a fix — torn between the party's demand to amplify the benefits of a new cash dole-out scheme and his own state's record of prudence in spending. He has been resolute so far. "If you listen to my campaign speeches during elections in other states, I never talk up such cash benefit schemes. I focus on everything else," the CM says.

But why would the CM upset his party colleagues in other states by not talking up the benefits of cash transfers? He is candid. "My people are shrewd. The day I laud, praise and advertise such schemes

A senior bureaucrat, who has worked closely with the Prime Minister says his instinct is to call out his own Cabinet colleagues during meetings when they pitch populist schemes

— even if announced by my own party — in other states, my people will demand the same. I cannot afford to go down that path. So I avoid promoting such promises made in the manifesto," he says. His state is among those with a reasonably good financial health.

But the other Chief Minister's state is not in such good shape. In fact, no sooner did this CM take charge, he realised what he inherited. Being in a party in the Opposition INDIA bloc, he did not expect the BJP-ruled Central government to bail him out for the excesses of a political party in power before him. So exasperated was he with the finances of his state that in an informal meeting with the Prime Minister, one of the first things he told him in private was to do something about these cash handouts. The Prime Minister had kicked off a big political storm when he referred to such sops as "*revdi*" while inaugurating an expressway in Uttar Pradesh in July 2022.

This newly elected CM, most likely, got a patient hearing from the Prime Minister. "I told Prime Minister Modi that the only way to stop political parties from this race to the bottom is to bring a Constitutional amendment and fix a cap on such expenditures," the Chief Minister said.

This, from a CM who belongs to the Congress, a party that more than matches the BJP in announcing cash transfers,

comes across as a leap of faith. But then, the nearly decade-long rule of his predecessor had led to an almost tripling of the state's outstanding debt. More and more debt means higher interest payments. Together with salary and pension, such committed expenditure puts enormous strain on the state's ability to spend money elsewhere — be it for schools and hospitals or highways and development work.

But realpolitik hasn't spared even the Prime Minister, who has a reputation of being tightfisted. A senior bureaucrat, who has worked closely with the Prime Minister says his instinct is to call out his own Cabinet colleagues during meetings when they pitch populist schemes. A telling example was how he finally allowed for a completely free rice and wheat scheme under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana. "Once you make it free, there is no way you can even charge 10 paise per kg of rice or wheat," this aide said.

But can free rice or wheat be called a *revdi*? Defining a dole is always a slippery slope. One party's empowerment scheme can be a *revdi* for the rival party. This debate remains unresolved, but poses one of the biggest challenges today.

The writer is Managing Editor,
The Indian Express.
Off the Record is a fortnightly column



FINANCIAL STRESS, MISSELLING COULD BE AMONG REASONS LEADING TO PREMATURE EXITS

Premature life policy surrenders soar, overtake maturity payouts

‘Some purchase policies expecting FD-like returns, but discontinue them after seeing long lock-in periods & penalties’

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 11

BLAME IT on financial stress or misselling by insurers, surrenders and withdrawals of life insurance policies before maturity have been rising over the past five years. Payouts for surrenders and withdrawals increased from around 30% of total benefits paid to policyholders in FY22 to 38.3% in FY26, suggesting that a growing number of policyholders are exiting their policies before maturity.

In contrast, maturity benefits, or policyholders who completed the full policy term, declined from about 48% in 2021-22 to 36.9% in 2025-26, according to data obtained from insurance regulator IRDAI (Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority).

This means the number of policyholders exiting mid-way through the policy tenure is rising faster than those who completed the policy tenure.

“This could be due to misselling by insurers or financial constraints or stress of policyholders. This is not an ideal situation as policyholders don’t get the full benefit when they exit mid-way. They could even

make losses,” said an insurance official. In 2025-26, life insurers paid total benefits of Rs 7.3 lakh crore to policyholders, according to IRDAI data. As much as 38.3% of this is surrender/withdrawal, leading to premature payout of Rs 2.8 lakh crore during the financial year.

When compared to this, the maturity benefit paid by insurers after completing the full term is Rs 2.69 lakh crore.

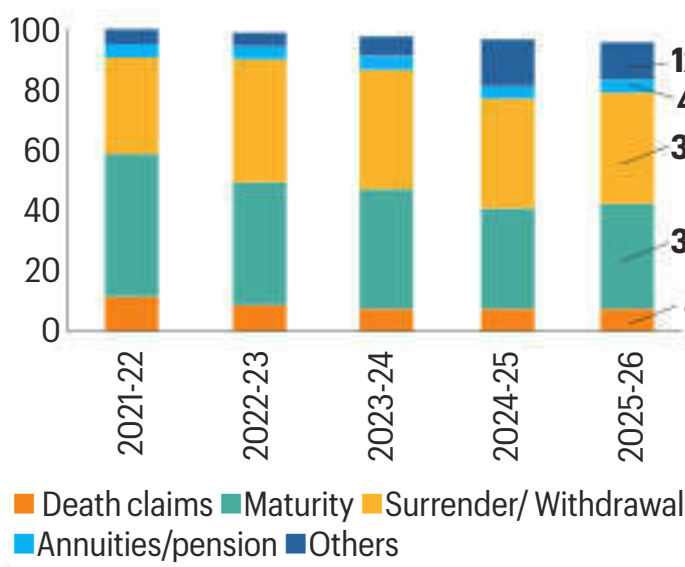
What’s leading to premature exits?

According to insurance experts, many families have surrendered traditional life insurance policies to meet immediate cash needs due to inflation, rising living costs and higher loan repayments in recent years. Some customers purchase policies expecting short-term investment or FD-like returns, but discontinue them after realising later about the long lock-in period and surrender penalties. Further, higher interest rates on bank FDs, stock market and mutual fund investments have become more attractive, prompting many customers to move away from insurance policies that offered comparatively lower returns, they say.

“The near parity between

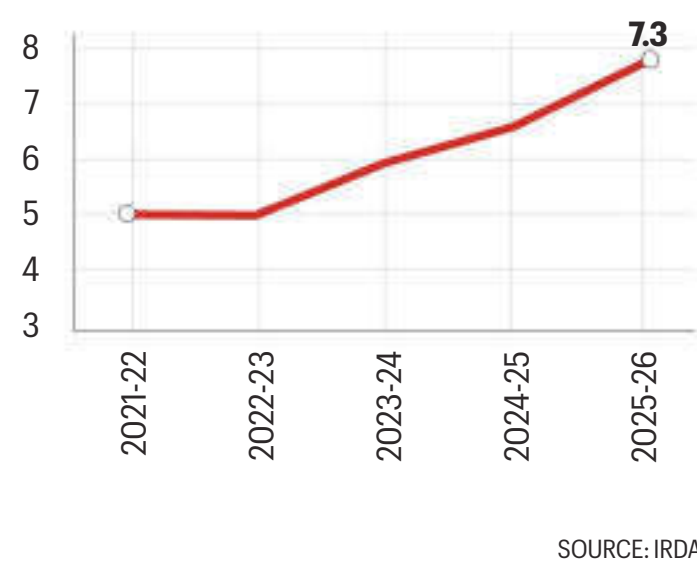
• CONCERNING TREND

Breakup of benefits paid by life insurers (in %)



Death claims Maturity Surrender/Withdrawal Annuities/pension Others

Total benefits paid by life insurers (in Rs lakh cr)



SOURCE: IRDAI

surrenders and maturity payouts indicates that policyholders are increasingly exiting policies prematurely. This shift has direct implications for asset-liability management (ALM), as early exits disrupt the long-duration assumptions underpinning life insurance investment strategies and can force asset liquidation ahead of schedule,” the RBI’s Financial Stability Report (FSR) says. Persistently elevated surrender rates also signal policyholder dissatisfaction, product misselling, or competitive pressure from alternative financial instruments, it says.

RBI and IRDAI had repeatedly warned against misselling by banks and NBFCs.

While the insurance sector remains broadly resilient, several underlying structural pressures exist from a financial stability perspective. Sustained

premium expansion has strengthened the sector’s ability to absorb shocks. However, elevated surrender behaviour in life insurance points to weaker policy persistence introduces uncertainty in asset-liability management, RBI’s FSR says.

Net incurred claims increase

Net incurred claims in the general insurance segment rose from Rs 1.4 lakh crore in 2021-22 to Rs 2.1 lakh crore in 2025-26, an increase of nearly 50% over five years, according to the IRDAI data.

Net claims paid is the amount paid to policyholders after accounting for any recoveries such as reinsurance.

This reflects rising frequency and severity of loss events, particularly in health and motor lines, which together constitute

95.3% of net incurred claims in 2025-26, IRDAI data shows.

Health insurance claims have grown to 55% of total net incurred claims, driven by medical inflation, rising hospitalisation rates and expanding coverage. Motor claims account for 40.3%.

The concentration of claims in these two segments creates correlated and structurally growing loss exposure that may strain reserving adequacy and underwriting margins, if not continuously recalibrated.

PSU general insurers continued to post the largest underwriting losses throughout the last five-year period, widening to Rs 31,000 crore in 2025-26 as against Rs 10,000 crore in the case of private insurers, IRDAI data shows.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

India seeks review of US’ forced labour investigation

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 11

INDIA HAS sought the review of proposed US tariffs of 12.5% citing inconsistencies in its Section 301 investigation into forced labour concerns, as the deadline for fresh US tariffs scheduled to be imposed by July 24 nears.

The US has currently imposed 10% global tariffs.

Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce Brij Mohan Mishra, during a public hearing, said that India takes the elimination of forced labour seriously as a Constitutional obligation, and as a matter of international law and principle.

“India would like to highlight its concerns with the USTR’s report and findings against India,” he said.

The USTR has not satisfied the relevant legal standards under Section 301(d) of the Trade Act. A mere absence of a forced labour import prohibition without evidentiary basis of other statutory requirements cannot be construed as unreasonable under Section 301, he added.

The USTR determination does not provide a rationale for countrywide tariffs and impermissibly clubs 46 economies (including India) into a single category, according to the written transcript of the hearing, held on July 8 and published on the USTR website.

The report, he said, relies on broad data and it presupposes that an economy’s imports flagged for this stuff involving imports made with forced labour are exported to the US without providing any sector or country-specific evidence and actual linkages with forced labour. In relation to India, there is inadequate and insufficient evidence that a lack of a forced labour import ban causes an unfair competitive advantage to the detriment of



The 12.5% US tariff could come into effect starting July 24. REUTERS

the American industry, he said.

“In conclusion, it is submitted that the USTR reconsider the imposition of tariffs in light of the identified inconsistencies in the report in the Federal Register notice. We ask that any trade problems be addressed within the framework of the India-US bilateral trade negotiation, not through unilateral measures such as this investigation,” he added.

Arguing on behalf of Indian industry, Anil Rajvanshi, President of Reliance Industries Limited (RIL), said that their petrochemical intermediates use crude oil and ethane sourced from low-risk origins, including the United States, and are far removed from sectors like agriculture where state-imposed forced labour is typically documented.

Furthermore, they do not subcontract to third-party factories and maintain a strict code of conduct subject to ESG audits. RIL pointed out that the US already imposes significant duties on Indian products like PSF and PET resin, with rates already in the mid-teens to high twenties. Adding a 12.5% Section 301 duty would stack tariffs to between 30 and 40%, which would increase costs and risk production cuts for US downstream users while having little impact on forced labour incentives, Rajvanshi said.

Rajvanshi warned that levying these tariffs would “kill the remaining small portion of the

textile industry that exists in the US” because the downstream industry requires a full value chain of raw materials at competitive prices to flourish.

Making submissions on behalf of Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA), Shreyans Gupta, First Secretary in the Embassy of India in Washington, DC, said that the export promotion body objects to the USTR’s observations on the import of rice allegedly made with forced labour into India and the alleged impact on such imports in distorting the competitive conditions for the export and domestic sale of rice produced in the US.

Gupta said that the overall value of rice imported into India in relation to the value of rice exported from India to the US is not even 3%.

He added that there are regulatory checks in place that prevent exports of imported rice from India that have been produced with forced labour.

Export of rice from India to the US is allowed only from the rice mills and processing units registered with the agriculture ministry.

“For these reasons, the present investigation against India may be rescinded without prejudice,” Gupta said, requesting exemption for Indian rice from the proposed duty if the proceedings continue.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Gaming industry winning despite a real money ban

Kunal Doley
New Delhi, July 11

REAL-MONEY gaming (RMG) may have been banned, but India’s gaming industry has not lost the game.

From in-app purchases to premium passes, cosmetic spending to subscriptions and advertising-led monetisation, the industry is rapidly expanding its revenue streams to sustain growth momentum since the ban that became effective from May 1 this year.

Long dependent on RMG as the primary driver of growth, the shift marks a significant milestone in the history of the industry as Indian gaming revenue breached the \$1-billion barrier for the first time last year, as per the latest Asia & MENA Games Market Model Report released by Niko Partners, a market research firm covering games, e-sports, and streaming in Asia.

The report further forecasts that the total revenue will grow 14% by the end of this year to nearly \$1.2 billion, and reach \$1.77 billion by 2030 at a 5-year CAGR of 11.2%. As per the firm, India is the fastest growing market in gaming in Asia and MENA region.

As per Niko Partners, there were nearly 511 million players

in India in 2025, and it expects the number to reach nearly 707 million by 2030, growing at a CAGR of 6.7% during the forecast period.

“India became the world’s largest market for game downloads a few years ago, which showed just how many people were playing games. What’s exciting now is that the market is evolving beyond downloads. People are spending more time playing, exploring a wider variety of games, and increasingly paying for experiences they enjoy,” said Sidharth Kedia, chief strategy and investments officer at NODWIN Gaming, a company focused on e-sports, gaming and youth entertainment. “For several years, discussions around India’s gaming industry remained synonymous with real-money gaming. However, the broader gaming ecosystem has been expanding rapidly underneath that narrative,” said Sagar Nair, head of incubation at LVL Zero, a gaming incubator backed by Nazara Technologies, MIXI Global Investments, and ChimeraVC.

Today, revenue growth is increasingly being supported by in-app purchases, battle passes, subscriptions, cosmetic spending, advertising-led monetisation, and live-service game ecosystems. FE

• IT IS ONE OF THE WORLD’S LONGEST AND MOST POWERFUL (2,400 KILOWATT) HYDROGEN TRAINSETS

PM to flag off India’s first hydrogen train: Why the technology is so challenging

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 11

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will flag off India’s first hydrogen-powered train in Jind, Haryana on July 17. This will mark a major milestone for the Indian Railways in a green technology where few countries have ventured so far.

According to the Railways, this is one of the world’s longest (eight passenger cars and two driving power cars) and most powerful (2400 kilowatt) hydrogen trainsets.

The train can carry at least 682 passengers on the 89-km Jind-Sonapat railway section at a maximum operational speed of 75 km/h. It will make two round trips a day, covering 356 km and consuming an estimated 300 kg of hydrogen.

Hydrogen is highly flammable and needs to be transported at very high pressure. How will the Railways do this? And how will the train work? We explain. **HYDROGEN TRAINS ELSEWHERE**

French rolling stock giant Alstom presented the technology for the first time at a 2016 exhibition in Berlin. Its two-car trainset, the Coradia iLint, was launched in Germany two years later, becoming the world’s first hydrogen-powered passenger train.

Later, countries such as Japan, China and the US also launched their own hydrogen-powered trains.

The technology, however, is still evolving to cater to the mass transportation of passengers and freight. That is why few countries have hydrogen train services, and those that do

use them mostly for relatively short trips.

HOW THESE TRAINS WORK

Normal electrical locomotives require overhead wires to draw the alternating current that powers their movement. Hydrogen trains don’t. They run on the simple formula of combining hydrogen with oxygen to produce the tractive electricity.

In the Indian hydrogen train’s case, each of the two driving power cars will have four sets of integrated power packs, comprising hydrogen fuel cells and a lithium ferro phosphate battery. The hydrogen fuel cell will draw in the hydrogen stored on board (440 kg) at high pressure and oxygen from the outside air, then combine them to release electrical energy. One power



The technology, however, is evolving. A handful of countries use them mostly for short trips. PHOTO: NORTHERN RAILWAYS

pack will release 300 kW of energy — 115 kW from the fuel cell and 185 kW from the lithium ferro phosphate battery. The four power packs will provide 1200 kW of power.

Since the train has two power cars, the total power gen-

erated doubles to 2400 kW (3200 hp). This is comparable to the horsepower generated by normal ‘electric multiple unit’ or ‘diesel-electric multiple unit’ trains that cover similar, short-haul distances.

A senior Northern Railway

official said that the train was essentially created by replacing the diesel engines on old ‘diesel electric multiple unit’ rakes with a zero-emission hydrogen-electric propulsion system. The official explained the working of the power pack of the hydrogen cell and battery. “The fuel cell provides a constant power output, meaning it does not fluctuate with the train’s changing power demand. When the train starts moving, it initially draws the power from the fuel cell, and since the train’s power requirement at that stage is lower, the surplus electricity from the fuel cell goes into charging the onboard battery. As the train reaches higher speed and its power demand increases, the battery kicks in

to provide power in addition to the fuel cell,” he said.

“Later, when the train’s power requirement goes down, especially when the train is nearing the station, the battery power cuts off and the excess energy of the fuel cell starts charging the battery. Thus, after covering a complete circuit, the battery is almost 80% charged at the end of the journey,” said the official.

The main part of the system — the fuel cell — has been imported from the Canadian company Ballard, which specialises in its production.

STORING AND SUPPLYING HYDROGEN

Normal atmospheric pressure is measured as one “bar”. Hydrogen, however, has to be

stored at 200-500 bar. This is the biggest challenge in using hydrogen as a clean fuel in trains. There are other issues too. Hydrogen production levels are low and transporting is difficult. To ensure the continuous supply of hydrogen for the trains, the railways has set up a 3000-kg-capacity fueling facility at Jind. A chiller plant has also been developed to keep the hydrogen at minus 15 degrees Celsius during dispensing — the low temperature will transform it into a liquid state and, thus, ensure its easy dispensing. The Railways, however, has not yet announced any other hydrogen train project. The official quoted above said that the future of the project would depend on how the first train works. FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

IRAN THREATENS TO AVENGE SUPREME LEADER'S KILLING

US seeks Iranian pledge to free up Strait of Hormuz

Parisa Hafezi
& Steve Holland

Dubai, Washington, July 11

IRAN'S FOREIGN Minister Abbas Araqchi arrived in Oman on Saturday to discuss arrangements for the safe passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz, with Washington seeking a public pledge of free, secure transit.

US President Donald Trump said on Friday the US and Iran had agreed to continue talks despite an escalation of hostilities this week, while also declaring an end to the ceasefire reached between the two sides.

No attacks were reported on Friday or early Saturday, however, and a senior Iranian source told *Reuters* a call between Iran, the US, Qatar, and Pakistan had been agreed and mediators were trying to arrange it for Saturday while Araqchi is in Oman.

Oman is helping to mediate an end to a war that has spread insecurity in the Gulf and raised prices around the world since the US and Israel launched airstrikes on Iran on February 28.



Supporters of Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei. REUTERS

CBS News and its UK partner the BBC both reported that US Vice President JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, special envoy Steve Witkoff and Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner were expected to lead negotiations on Saturday with Araqchi. Iran's Fars news agency later cited a source saying no negotiations would take place until the U.S. retreated from its positions.

Three Qatari and Saudi commercial tankers came

under fire earlier in the week, prompting the US to hit Iranian sites, and Iran to respond with strikes on U.S. military sites in Gulf states. Araqchi accused the US of violating the ceasefire agreement; the U.S. revoked the license authorizing the sale of Iranian crude on Tuesday after the vessels were hit.

"There can only be mutual compliance," he wrote on X.

Meanwhile, a written statement from Iran's new supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba

Khamenei, on Saturday threatened vengeance for the death of his predecessor and father, who was killed on February 28.

Released to mark funeral ceremonies for former leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, which the new leader did not attend, it said the vengeance would take place whatever happened to Iran. "We pledge to avenge the blood of the martyred leader and all the martyrs," the message said.

Trump had posted on Friday that he had ordered the U.S. military to be prepared to launch thousands of missiles against Iran if Tehran attempted to assassinate him.

The Wall Street Journal and other U.S. media reported this week that Israel had shared intelligence with Washington that Iran had recently devised a plan to assassinate Trump. There was no immediate comment from Iran on Trump's latest remarks. At the funeral ceremonies on Thursday, a huge crowd of mourners packed a courtyard, some bearing banners reading, "We Will Kill Trump." REUTERS



Typhoon Bavi makes landfall in China

Rain clouds cover downtown before the arrival of Typhoon Bavi in Wenzhou, Zhejiang province, China, on Saturday. More than 1.8 million people were evacuated from several cities including Beijing as emergency response measures have been stepped up, authorities said. REUTERS

Meta appeals verdict that blamed it for social media addiction among youth

Kaitlyn Huamani
July 11

META, THE parent company of Instagram and Facebook, has appealed the verdict of a landmark social media addiction lawsuit in Los Angeles, challenging the jury's determination that the company designed its platforms to hook young users without concern for their well-being.

Lawyers representing Meta filed a notice of appeal Tuesday in Los Angeles County Superior Court. The lawyers will provide their arguments related to the appeal in subsequent court filings. The case centered on a 20-year-old woman who said she became addicted to social media as a child and that it wor-



Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg

sened her mental health struggles. The jury found that negligence by both Meta and Google-owned YouTube, which was also a defendant in the case, was a substantial factor in causing harm to the young woman, identified in court only by her initials, KGM, and her first name, Kaley.

The jury awarded her \$3 million in damages and recom-

mended an additional \$3 million in punitive damages. Her lead attorney, Mark Lanier, said in a statement Friday that the legal team is expecting the appellate court to "continue the careful application of the law to this case, affirming the verdict of the trial court."

A notice of appeal starts what can be a lengthy process. A Meta spokesperson provided a statement Friday that they also gave when the jury returned the verdict in March, saying that teen mental health is "profoundly complex and cannot be linked to a single app." José Castañeda, a spokesperson for Google, said in a statement Friday that YouTube plans to appeal and that "these are standard motions for this case to move forward." AP